

# Travel Diary

## Sicily at Easter



*Route: Catania → Enna → Castelbuono → Etna → Syracuse → Ragusa → Caltagirone*  
*Thu April 17 – Sat April 26, 2025*

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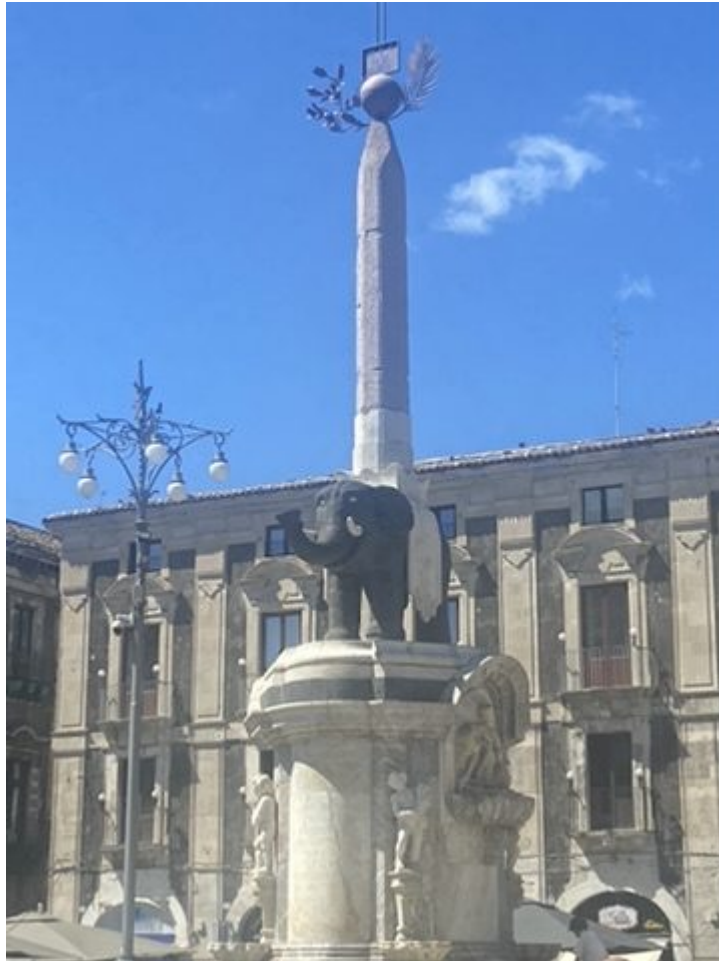
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## Day 1 – Maundy Thursday, April 17 – Catania

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**Catania:** Landing in Catania, Sicily's second city at the foot of Etna. After the 1693 earthquake it was rebuilt in Baroque style, often in black lava stone. Its landmark stands on Piazza del Duomo: "U Liotru", a lava-stone elephant carrying an Egyptian obelisk, set up in 1736 by Giovanni Battista Vaccarini. Right next to it, the cathedral of the city's patron saint, Sant'Agata.







**Roman Theatre:** Right among the houses lies the Roman theatre from the 2nd century, partly built over by the old town. In the passages beneath it you can see the dark lava rock Catania stands on.







A must in Sicily: cannoli, fried pastry tubes filled with sweet ricotta.





**Fish market:** "A Piscaria", the fish market behind the cathedral, is loud, wet and full of life – mussels, swordfish, the calls of the traders. With a Vespa in tricolore paint right in the middle.





**On to Enna:** In the evening inland to Pergusa on the lake of the same name below Enna – and the first pizza.



## Day 2 – Good Friday, April 18 – Good Friday Procession in Enna

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**Enna:** Enna sits at around 930 m and is known as the "navel of Sicily" – Italy's highest provincial capital, with views across the whole interior of the island. The octagonal Torre di Federico is attributed to Emperor Frederick II.





**The Good Friday procession:** Good Friday is the high point of the year in Enna. The tradition dates back to Spanish rule: thousands of members of the confraternities walk silently through the town in robes and pointed hoods, each brotherhood in its own colours. They carry the urn with the dead Christ and the statue of Our Lady of Sorrows from the cathedral along Via Roma. It is one of the most striking Holy Week processions in Italy.















## Day 3 – Holy Saturday, April 19 – Castel di Tusa & Castelbuono

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**Castel di Tusa:** Right across the island to the north coast. Lunch directly on the pebble beach of Castel di Tusa, with wine from the barrel.





**Castelbuono:** The little town in the Madonie mountains grew up around the Ventimiglia castle, built from 1316. On Piazza Margherita stands the Matrice Vecchia, the old mother church from the 14th century, with frescoes in its crypt. Castelbuono is also known for its pastries and ice cream.











## Day 4 – Easter Monday, April 21 – Wednesday, April 23 – Mount Etna

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**Up Mount Etna:** From Nicosia across the interior to Etna. At around 3,300 m it is Europe's highest active volcano and a UNESCO World Heritage Site since 2013. An off-road bus takes us up the north side near Linguaglossa into the lava fields, between craters and cushions of milk-vetch, with snow still lying higher up.







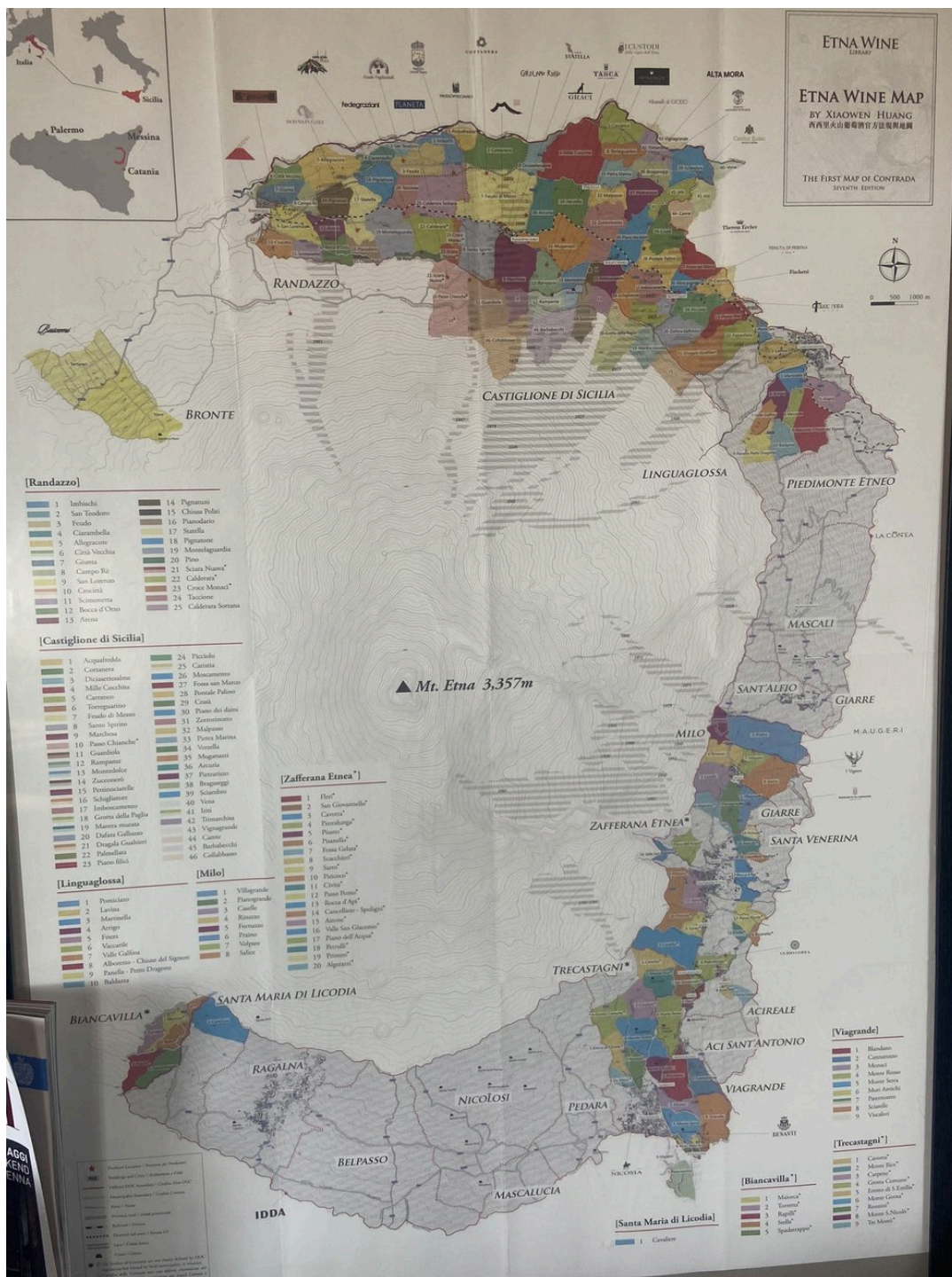
**Etna wine:** The lava soils make Etna one of Italy's most exciting wine regions: Nerello Mascalese for red, Carricante for white; Etna DOC has existed since 1968. In the evening at a wine bar in Linguaglossa, on Wednesday at a winery near Milo. In between, a giant bench with a view over the volcanic slope.













## Day 5 – Wednesday, April 23 – Syracuse & Ortigia

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**Syracuse:** Founded around 734 BC by Greeks from Corinth, Syracuse was once one of the most powerful cities of the ancient world and home of Archimedes. The Neapolis archaeological park holds the Greek theatre and the Latomia del Paradiso, a vast ancient quarry.



**Ortigia and the cathedral:** The old-town island of Ortigia is linked to the mainland by two bridges. The cathedral is a palimpsest: behind the 1728 Baroque façade stand the Doric columns of the 5th-century-

BC temple of Athena – you can still see them in the walls inside. UNESCO World Heritage since 2005.







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## Day 6 – Thursday, April 24 – Modica & Ragusa Ibla

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**Modica:** Modica and Ragusa are among the eight towns of the Val di Noto rebuilt in late Baroque style after the 1693 earthquake – UNESCO World Heritage together since 2002. Modica is also famous for its chocolate, cold-processed after an Aztec model so it stays grainy.





**Ragusa Ibla:** After the earthquake some residents rebuilt the upper town, while others stayed in old Ibla on its rocky spur – two towns only reunited in 1926. From the church of Santa Maria delle Scale you look out over the whole old town stepping down the slope.











## Day 7 – Friday, April 25 – Villa Romana del Casale & Caltagirone

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**Villa Romana del Casale:** Near Piazza Armerina lies the villa of a wealthy Roman from the early 4th century, buried for centuries under a landslide. That preserved some 3,500 m<sup>2</sup> of floor mosaics, the largest such collection in the Roman world: hunting scenes, animals shipped from Africa and the famous "bikini girls" doing sport. UNESCO World Heritage since 1997.







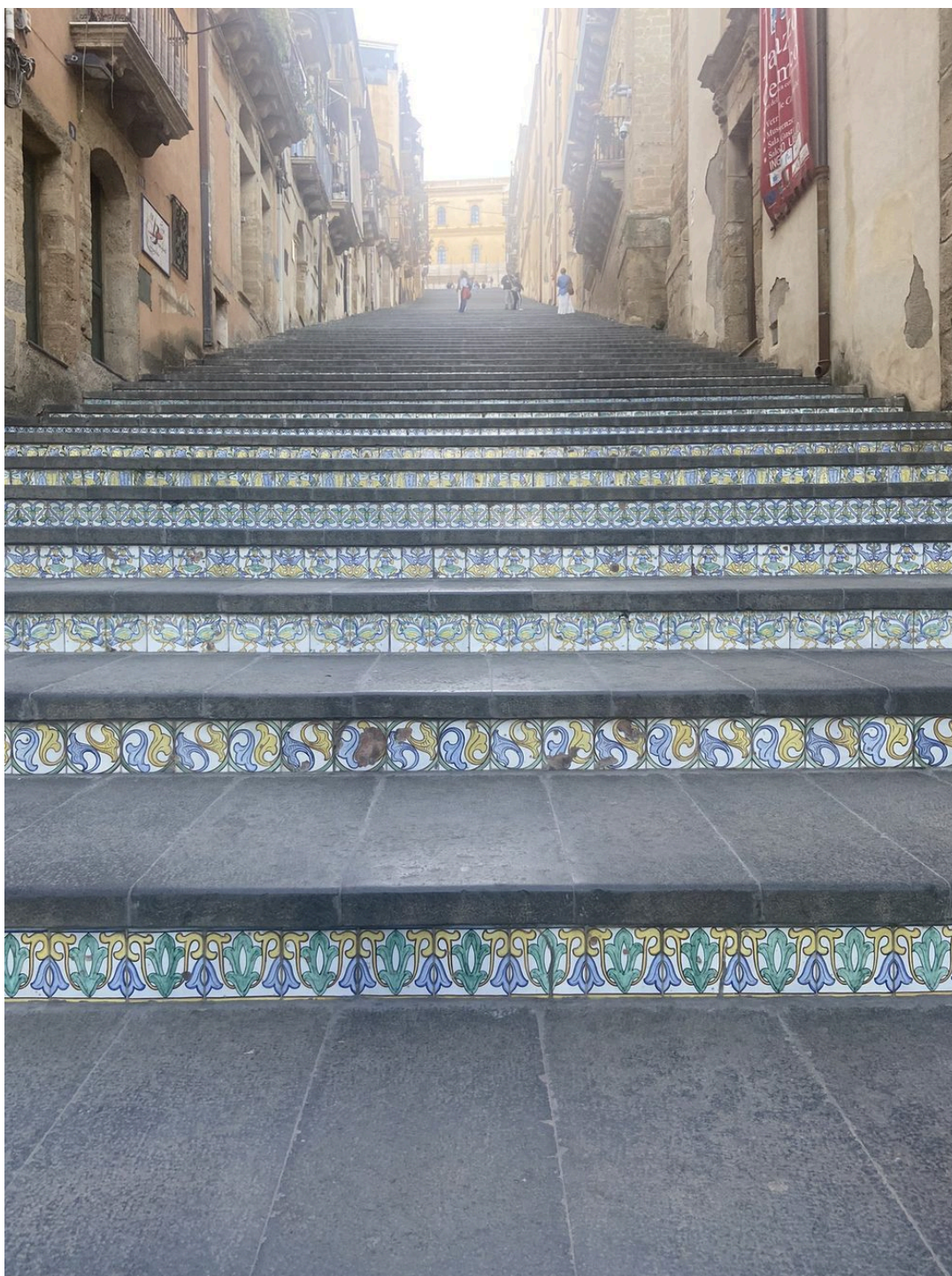








**Caltagirone:** The ceramics town of Caltagirone is also part of the Val di Noto. Its landmark is the Scala di Santa Maria del Monte: 142 steps, each riser covered in hand-painted majolica tiles. In one church stands a large nativity landscape – crib-making has a long tradition here.









**Farewell:** On Saturday, April 26, we fly home from Catania.

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